

Assignment Lost and Found: Meaning, Practice and Creativity in Translation

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- I. Please translate the following text into Chinese. Highlight or mark any AI/MT-assisted portions in bold in your translation. Any missed declaration will be considered academic misconduct.

It is easy to see the beginnings of things, and harder to see the ends. I can remember now, with a clarity (清楚、明晰) that makes the nerves in the back of my neck constrict (收縮、束縛), when New York began for me, but I cannot lay my finger upon the moment it ended, can never cut through the ambiguities (模稜兩可) and second starts and broken resolves (決心) to the exact place on the page where the heroine (女英雄) is no longer as optimistic as she once was. When I first saw New York I was twenty, and it was summertime, and I got off a DC-7 at the old Idlewild temporary terminal in a new dress which had seemed very smart in Sacramento but seemed less smart already, even in the old Idlewild temporary terminal, and the warm air smelled of mildew (發霉) and some instinct (本能、直覺), programmed by all the movies I had ever seen and all the songs I had ever heard sung and all the stories I had ever read about New York, informed me that it would never be quite the same again.

Of course it might have been some other city, had circumstances been different and the time been different and had I been different, might have been Paris or Chicago or even San Francisco, but because I am talking about myself I am talking here about New York. That first night I opened my window on the bus into town and watched for the skyline, but all I could see were the wastes of Queens and the big signs that said MIDTOWN TUNNEL THIS LANE and then a flood of summer rain (even that seemed remarkable and exotic, for I had come out of the West where there was no summer rain), and for the next three days I sat wrapped in blankets in a hotel room air-conditioned to 35° and tried to get over a bad cold and a high fever. Was anyone ever so young? I am here to tell you that someone was. All I could do during those three days was talk long-distance to the boy I already knew I would never marry in the spring. I would stay in New York, I told him, just six months, and I could see the Brooklyn Bridge from my window. As it turned out the bridge was the Triborough, and I stayed eight years.

In retrospect (回顧、回憶) it seems to me that those days before I knew the names of all the bridges were happier than the ones that came later, but perhaps you will see that as we go along. Part of what I want to tell you is what it is like to be young in New York, how six months can become eight years with the deceptive (虛偽的; 迷惑的) ease of a film dissolve (畫面溶暗), for that is how those years appear to me now, in a long sequence of sentimental dissolves and old-fashioned trick shots—the Seagram Building fountains dissolve into snowflakes, I enter a revolving (自轉) door at twenty and come out a good deal older, and on a different street. But most particularly I want to explain to you, and in the process perhaps to myself, why I no longer live in New York. It is often said that New York is a city for only the very rich and the very poor. It is less often said that New York is also, at least for those of us who came there from somewhere else, a city for only the very young.

*: *All the Chinese meanings added are not part of the original text.*

譯文：

送別

【美】琼·蒂蒂安

Goodbye to All That, Joan Didion

在故事的開始就知道結尾總是很困難的。現在我都還記得紐約帶給我的最初的感受，它也總是清晰地觸動著我的每一絲神經。但當這種感覺結束時，我也總不能再抓住它，也不再能憑它穿過朦朧惺忪和曾經的得而復失去找回過去那果斷堅信的自己。那是個夏天，二十歲的我第一次來到紐約，走下道格拉斯 DC-7 式客機，走出艾德維爾德機場的臨時航站樓，穿着有點背時的山克拉們都新裙子，拂來的空氣都帶著點濕氣。這是一種直覺，是那些我曾看過的關於紐約的電影，聽過的關於紐約的歌，以及所有我看過的關於紐約的故事，它們告訴我，曾經的一切已不會再重演。

當然，這座城市可以是巴黎，可以是芝加哥，甚至也可以是聖弗朗西斯科，但這樣的話，要談論的情境就會不同，時間也會不同，而我也不會相同。但當我談起我的時候，我談論紐約，因為我在紐約。來到紐約的第一晚，下着雨，我打開了入城巴士的窗想要遠觀摩天大樓，可我只看到了皇后區裏堆著的拉圾和指往市中心的路牌。可能是來自西部的原因，夏天這裏的雨總顯得陌生而又壯觀。後面的三天，我得了重感冒，但酒店的空調實在是太冷了。我只能裹在毛毯裏，想着這樣或許會好受些。你說真的有人會這麼蠢嗎？就像三天發着燒來回給一個明知不會和他結婚的男孩打長途電話？我告訴他我會在紐約待六個月，跟他講從我的房間可以看到布魯克林橋。事實上，我待了八年，那座橋叫羅伯特·肯尼迪。

印象中，在我記全所有橋名字之前的日子比晚些時要似乎更快樂，但這都是後話了。我想說的是，在紐約，「年輕」意味着什麼，又如何讓日子八年如六月般地消溶卻又故作輕鬆。因為，這就是往昔於我如今，當西格拉姆大廈前的噴泉凝成雪花，當大廈入口的門旋轉不止，出來時一條異樣的街，感到悵然若失。但我最想要藉此訴說的，是我為什麼離開了紐約。常言，紐約是一座極端的城市，它只接受貧富分明。但，除此之外，至少對於像我們這樣來自其他地方的人來說，紐約僅僅屬於青春一瞬。

II. (300 words) According to what you learnt from class, please write a commentary on your translation strategies, principles, and standards with at least one example in your translation.

Nearly at the end of the text, Didion writes about her feeling towards her old days back in New York from her current perspective through a film-like technique: “film dissolve”, “sentimental dissolves”, and “old-fashioned trick shots”. In brief, the source text is excerpted from Didion’s autobiography, which makes the text lie more under the syllabus of literary translation. However, the words used by Didion are a little academic since the techniques she lists are all strategies used in a film shot, and a direct translation of these words into Chinese will make the target text stiff. To be specific, by translating “old-fashioned trick shots” directly into “老式特效技巧”, the words in Chinese make a direct link between its signifier to what it signified. This weakens the expression of Didion’s sentiment towards the old days. Therefore, what matters here is what the readers will feel through experiencing such techniques. All the sceneries mix up together within a short time and switch smoothly thus brings out a feeling of unconsciousness and losing.

Therefore, for translation, a direct translation of words will be abandoned. Luckily, Didion informed us about what the film techniques do to her memory after the listing of techniques and thus makes that part essential while translating. “Long sequence” shows the during of shooting. Therefore, the translation extends the sentence. “Old-fashioned trick shots” make the sceneries change and dissolve together smoothly, so the translation focused on the word “大厦” as an anchor and moves the viewpoint from the fountain to the revolving door. At last, Didion feels “sentimental”. Thus, the latter part shrinks the length of sentence to make a pause in rhythm and an atmosphere of nothingness surround.

In addition, the target text uses two “and-s” at last. This provides an emphasis on the weightlessness the memories bring to Didion. In order to achieve such effect, the translation uses two “當” to make a complement to that.

(word account: 329)